CSH interview: easy guide

Tuesday 20 October, 8:40 pm Lahore time (4:40 pm UK) · Zoom, meeting ID 843 5332 6447 · about 10 minutes · recorded · in English

1. the cheat sheet

What they want to know: do you fit CSH, and can you do careful, independent research? Questions are about your experience and your interests. Nothing to study; just be clear and honest.

Your three messages

- **Your question:** when AI reads social media posts, do its labels mean the same thing on every platform? If not, how do we fix the comparison?
- **Your proof:** your first paper, with Dr Ella Haig, published on arXiv last week.
- **Your strength:** eight years working with social media data, so data is never your problem.

Your 60-second story (learn this)

> "My work has always been about social media data, and it grew step by step. At Dubizzle I first saw online text drive real business decisions, in four languages. That led to my Chevening idea: one system that compares platforms to show government what the public thinks. I built a small version in my MSc, and found my own check was circular. At Fluency I work with social media at scale for brands and UK government, and at my start-up, Artemis AI, I learned that AI labels can look fine exactly when they are wrong. My first paper turns these lessons into a method. A PhD at CSH is the next step: doing this properly, with network science."

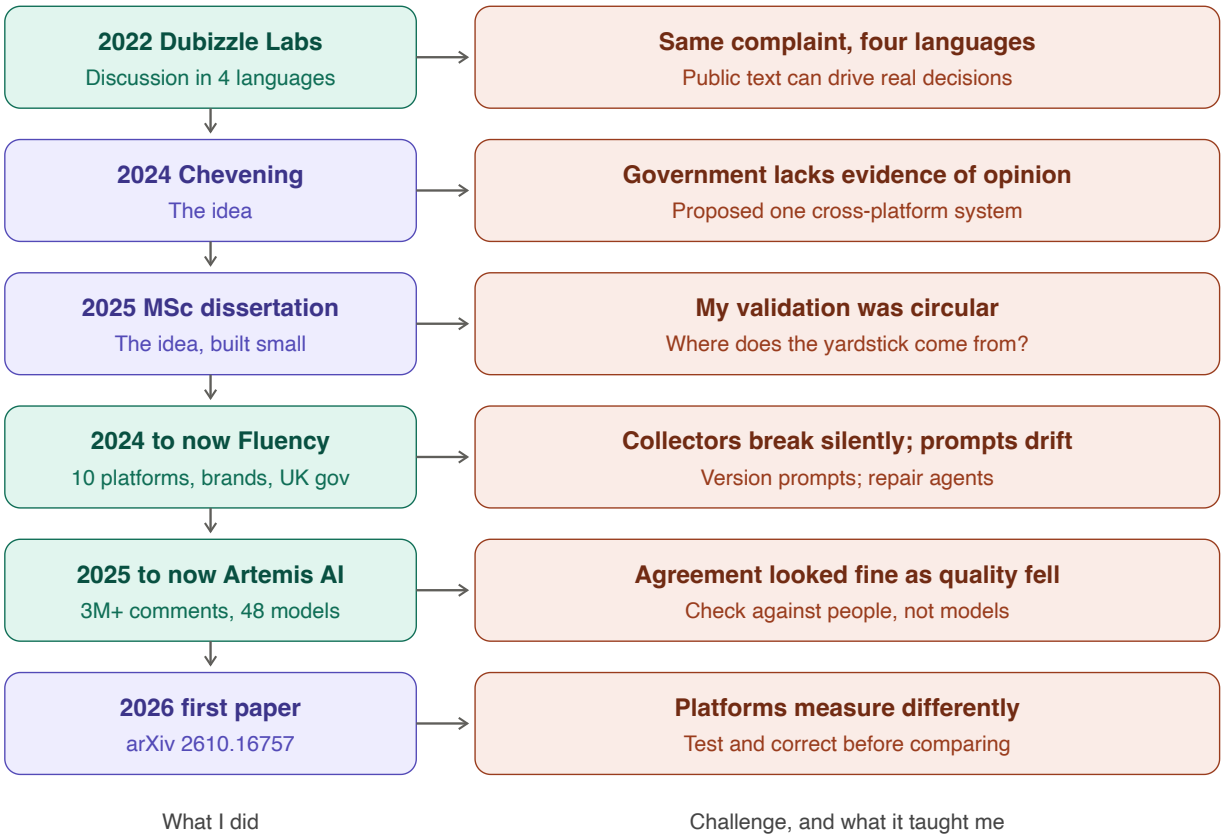
One line that ties it to the PhD

> "Every job showed me a new way social media measurements fail. The PhD is where I learn to test and fix them, and see how the fix changes what we conclude about narratives and polarisation."

Numbers to keep the same as your application

255,446 comments (MSc) **Team of eight at Artemis AI** **3 million+ comments**
arXiv 2610.16757 **MSc Distinction, Chevening 2024/25**

2. your story, step by step



1. Dubizzle Labs (2022–2024)

Built the company's first web data system: 15 markets, four languages, a team of three. Dashboards showed what customers said online. **For the PhD:** you know how the same opinion reads differently across languages.

2. Chevening (2024)

Won for helping students into remote careers, and for an idea: one system comparing social media platforms to give government evidence of public opinion. **For the PhD:** your question is years old and useful to the public, not a trend.

3. MSc dissertation (2025)

Built the Chevening idea small: 255,446 comments from X, Reddit, YouTube and Quora about UK economic policy. Then you found the check on your AI model was circular. **For the PhD:** you can find the flaw in your own work and turn it into research.

4. M+C Saatchi Fluency (2024–now)

Social media from ten platforms every day, for big brands and UK government. You record which prompt produced every AI label, and built AI agents that fix broken data collectors. **For the PhD:** you can build clean, repeatable datasets from day one.

5. Artemis AI (2025–now)

Your start-up: 3 million+ comments, 48 models, a team of eight. The hard lessons:

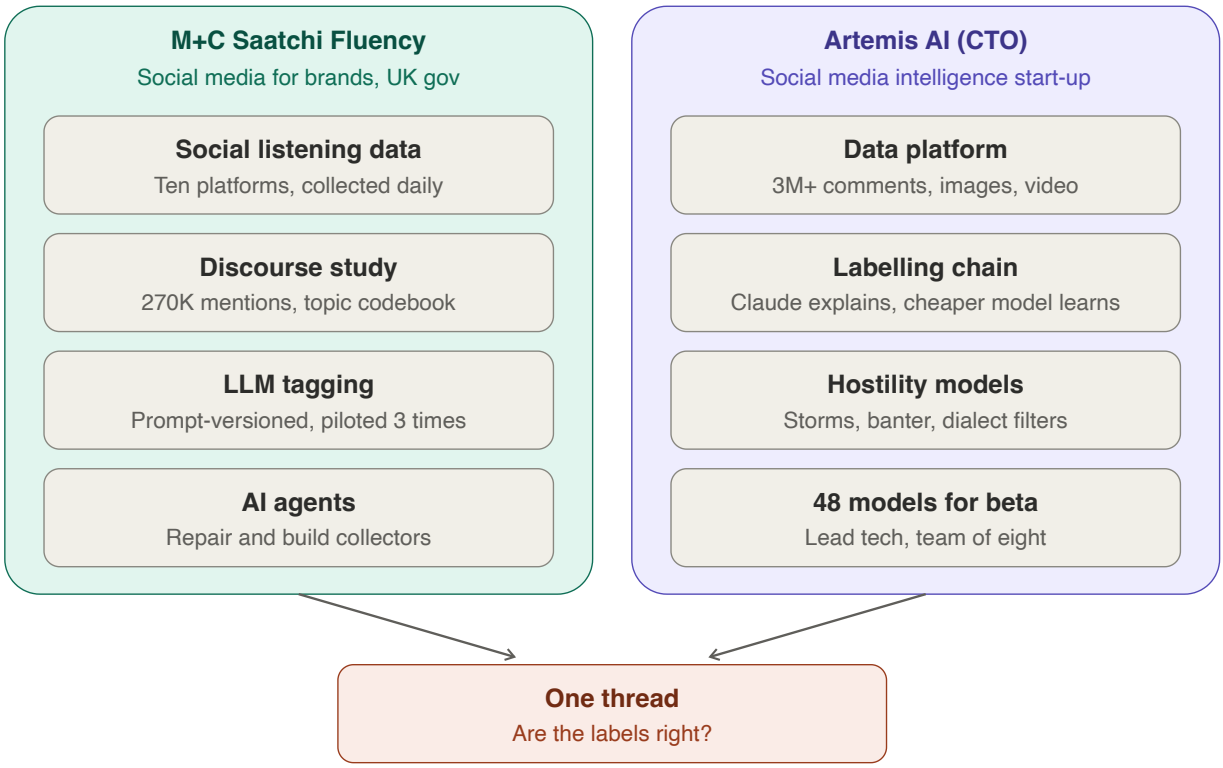
- **Agreement can lie:** two AI models agreed more while both got worse. Always check against people.
- **Labels drift:** one measure fell from 77% agreement to 37% in weeks without anyone noticing.
- **“Normal” is hard:** out of 207,192 comments on busy posts, almost none were real storms. Each page needs its own baseline.
- **Words depend on the group:** banter and dialect get mistaken for abuse.

For the PhD: checking AI labels against people is exactly what CSH’s Alexander Hoyle works on.

6. Your first paper (October 2026)

All of this became one method: test whether platforms can be compared, and fix them if not. **For the PhD:** it is chapter one, already done.

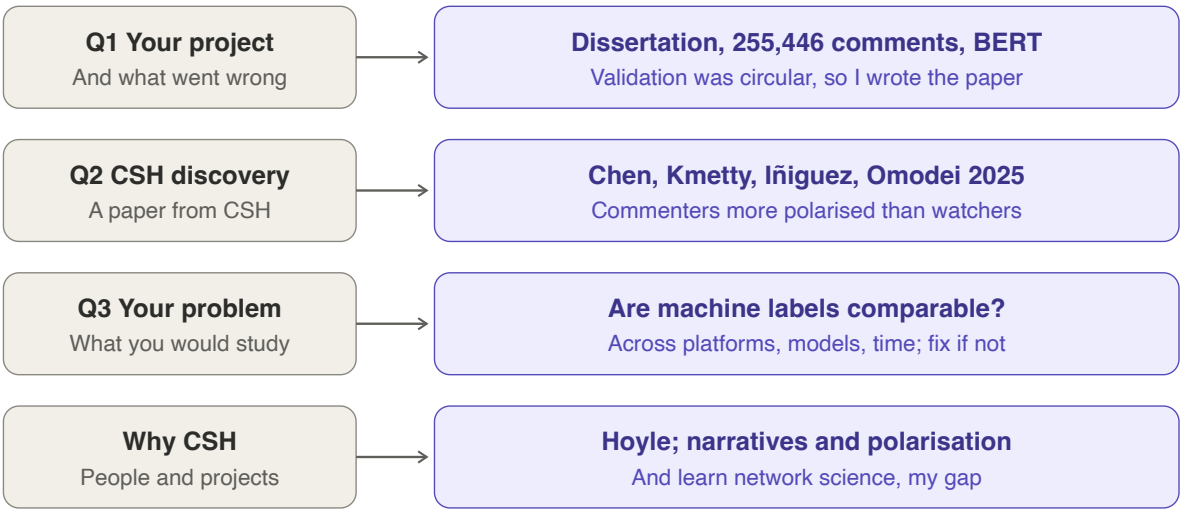
3. what you did at Fluency and Artemis AI



> “Brands and governments act on AI-labelled numbers that are rarely checked against people. My PhD would build the methods to check them.”

4. what you told CSH in your application

The interview recording is read together with these answers, so say the same things.



Answer 1: your project

Your MSc dissertation compared reactions to UK economic policy on four platforms. The AI model looked very accurate, but it had been trained and checked on labels from the same simple word list (VADER), so the check proved nothing. You also assumed “negative” means the same on every site. **Lesson:** always ask where your yardstick comes from.

Answer 2: a CSH paper you liked

Chen, Kmetty, Iñiguez and Omodei (2025): people who *comment* on political YouTube videos are more polarised than people who only *watch*. So studies built on comments make society look more divided than it is. **Your idea:** could a small group of people who donate their data be used to correct millions of public comments?

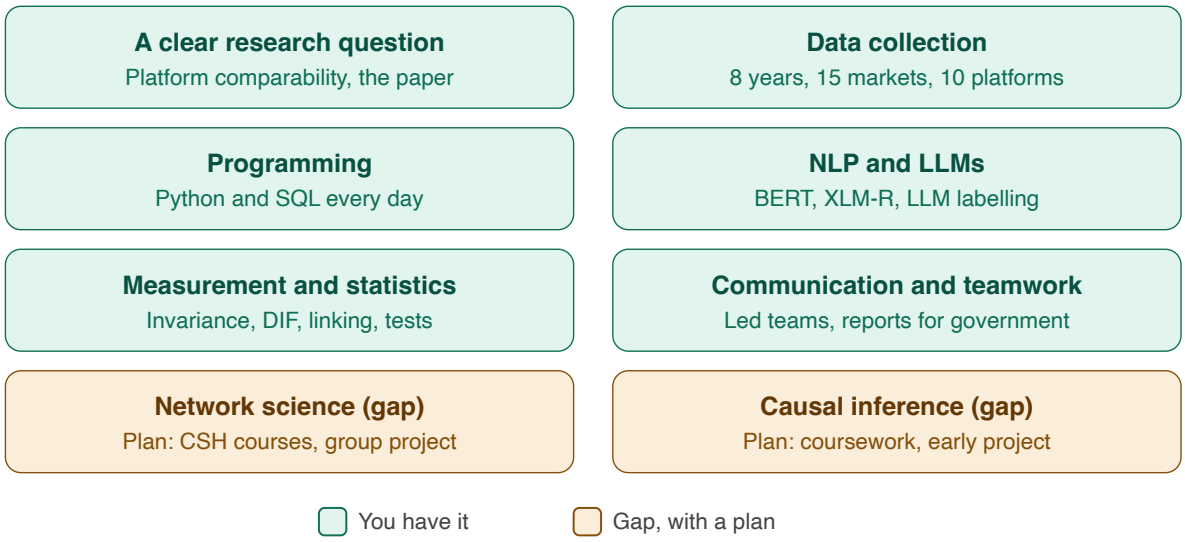
Answer 3: what you want to study

When can we compare AI-labelled opinions across platforms, AI models and time, and how do we fix them when we can’t? Four steps: extend your simulation; collect new posts around fixed events, labelled by several AIs and checked by people; test whether removing the “platform signal” removes real differences; then see how the fix changes how narratives seem to spread.

People and projects you named (all checked)

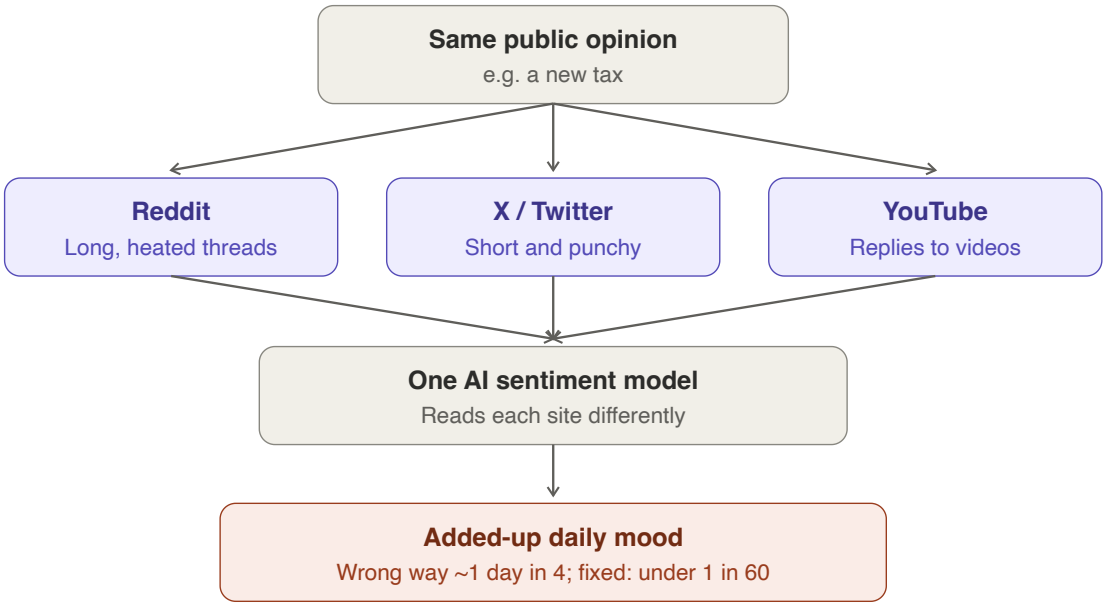
- **Alexander Hoyle**, CSH faculty: checking whether AI text measures really measure what they claim. Closest to you.
- **Elisa Omodei**, CSH faculty: co-author of the paper in Answer 2.
- Springboard projects: **Understanding narratives at scale**; **Polarization and minority representation on online platforms**.

5. what this PhD needs, and what you bring



Green: you already have it. Amber: you don't yet, and CSH teaches it, which is a good reason to do the PhD there.

6. your paper in 20 seconds



> "People write differently on Reddit than on YouTube, so AI reads their opinions differently. Adding platforms together can flip the answer: in my simulation, the overall mood pointed the wrong way on nearly a quarter of days. My paper gives a checklist to test whether a comparison is fair, and a way to fix it."

7. likely questions, short answers

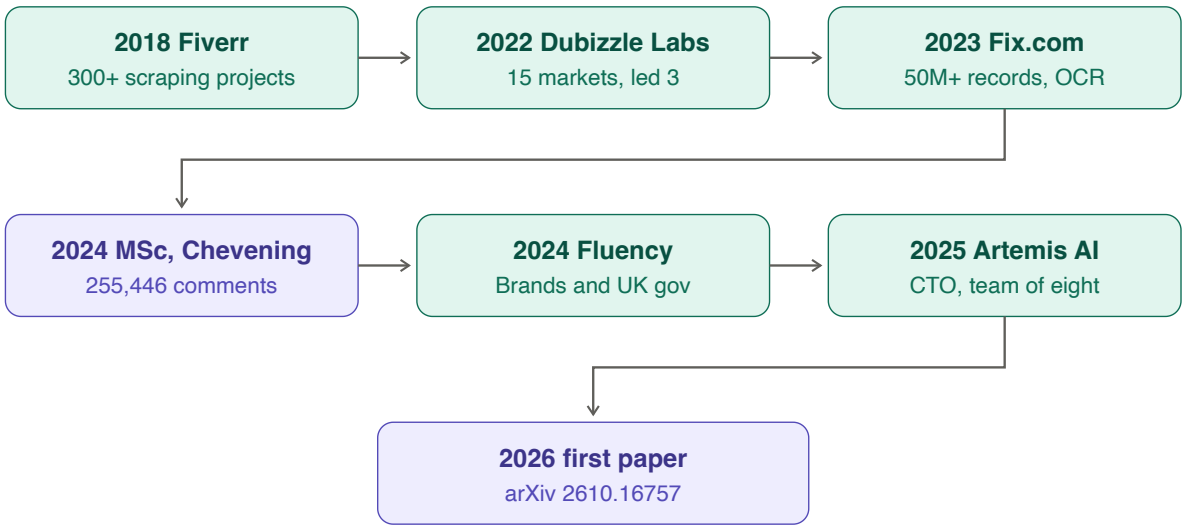
Aim for 45–75 seconds. Say the main point first, give one example, then stop.

Question	Main points
Tell us about yourself	The 60-second story on page 1.
A research project, and what went wrong	MSc dissertation → the circular check → you found it yourself → it became the paper.
What have you built in industry?	Fluency: prompt-recorded AI labels, repair agents. Artemis AI: “agreement can lie”. Then the one line in section 3.
Why a PhD, why now?	Every job showed a new way measurements fail; industry let you find problems but not study them; CSH gives network science and causal inference.
Why CSH?	Opinion online is a system of people, platforms and algorithms. Chen et al. and Hoyle’s work match your question. You want to learn network science.
What would you study?	Answer 3 in three steps: simulation, new data checked by people, effect on how narratives spread.
Strengths and gaps	Strengths: data at scale, Python, AI labelling, careful checking. Gaps: network science, causal inference, with a plan.
Teamwork	Led three engineers at Dubizzle and at VendueTech; lead the tech team of eight at Artemis AI.
A setback	The circular check: found it, admitted it, turned it into a paper.
Five years from now	Researching how online opinion is measured, so decisions rest on numbers checked against people.
Questions for us?	“How are students matched with supervisors in the first year?”

8. on the day, and what comes next

- Join at **8:35 pm**. Test camera and microphone. Quiet room, light in front of you, look at the camera.
- Keep this guide open but don’t read from it. A short pause before answering is fine.
- Recording is normal; just go ahead.

If you pass: in 7–14 January you present a paper CSH chooses. Past choices were classic network papers: Watts and Strogatz 1998 (small worlds), Albert, Jeong and Barabási 2000 (network attacks), Clauset, Moore and Newman 2008 (missing links), Couzin et al. 2011 (group decisions). Start reading them after Tuesday. Finalists visit Vienna on 15–16 February; offers by mid-March. Referee letters must arrive by **1 November**.



Sources: CSH Graduate Program FAQ, DIS faculty list and springboard projects (csh.ac.at); CSH invitation email of 14 Oct; your CSH answers, CV and portfolio; Artemis AI shared notes and admin panel; PhD interview guides (AcademicPositions, Researcher.Life).